

Most myths, as was pointed out in the first two classes, follow some basic outlines. This is simply a variation on that idea and is a form that is followed by many fertility myths and by the Book of Revelation in the bible. The importance of this is in the fact that Tolkien also followed the basic outline in his epic.

The basic myth follows this outline.

There is something wrong, chaos threatens the peace of the cosmos. Usually the threat comes from the sea but not always.

There is then a council called, an assembly of the gods, to decide what is to be done to handle the problem.

At this point a young god, usually a warrior, is either appointed or volunteers to go out and handle the problem.

There is a battle and victory on the part of the younger god who then returns to the assembly in victory.

At this point, he is installed as king, or chief god, and given rewards of some kind, such as a new palace, wives, etc.

A sacred marriage and marriage feast ensue and there is restoration of fertility to the land.

AKKADIAN MYTH: records that Ea and Anu, the gods of Mesopotamia, are threatened by Apsu and Tiamut, which represent fresh and salt water respectively.

This reflects a schism between the oldest of the gods, Tiamut being a dragon and female, and some of the newer deities. Tiamut represents chaos. Marduk, son of Ea, meets in council with the gods and strikes a bargain with his superiors. He is promised the power to declare fates and work miracles.

Marduk destroys Tiamat with the aid of the seven winds and then cuts her in half and creates the heaven and earth. He then creates humans out of her blood. A great feast is given to celebrate his victory and a palace is built.

We see the same scenario in many other stories.

In **Caananite** myth, El sends Baal to win victory over the sea (Yam). In Danial Chapter 7, it is the Ancient of Days who sends the Son of Man, who is Michael the archangel, to defeat chaos and evil.

In mythological passages in both Psalms and Isaiah we have YHWH with no intermediary defeating the Leviathen, which apparently is a sea monster of some type. For the Jews, the sea is the uncreated, where chaos reigns.

And finally, in the book of Revelation chapters 4 and 5 we have the same basic myth. The sea is calm (not in chaos) like glass and the assembly of the gods has become an assembly of the elders of the church.

In chapter 5 of Revelation, YHWH grants the gift of Kingship to Jesus voluntarily, rather than having Jesus have to make a deal for it as Marduk did with Ea and Anu.

The whole book ends then with a great feast with "the Lamb" and the church like a marriage. The Lamb being the groom and the church the bride.

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What does this have to do with the Lord of the Rings. It is in many respects the same story. The Council that met, and had been meeting, to discuss the problems that middle earth was undergoing as they tried to figure out what Sauron was up to.

Gandalf leads Frodo, Sam, Merry and Pippin to the council at Rivendell. Elrond's council is a turning point in the history of Middle earth and because he himself, with Gandalf and Galadriel, is the wisest of the assembled leaders of the West, his

solomn opening statement to them that some force greater than themselves has brought them together at this crisis carries special weight.

Here the council agrees that the Ring must be carried back to Mordor to be destroyed. A silence ensues until Frodo, overcoming "a great dread," speaks up with an effort to offer himself as carrier.

This is Frodo's free choice and he does not bargain for some kind of reward if he does so, as in the old combat myths. What will actually happen cannot be seen but Frodo realizes, as does Elrond, that if any one is to succeed it will be Frodo.

When he does succeed, the reward is bittersweet, as has been discussed. There is feasting and acknowledgement of what he has done but he is wounded, never to fully recover.

His reward is about 2 years after destroying the ring when he and Bilbo are taken from Grey Haven to the lands to the west, as has been discussed. It is Sam, not Frodo, who gets married and has a long life in the Shire, including being mayor.

The parallels are, of course, not total, but there is significant similarities to this basic story that we need to be aware of its construction.

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PROMETHEUS:

There is one ancient Greek myth that tells of the forging of the first ring. This story is bound up with the tale of the coming of the gods and the creation of man.

The titans were the giant sons and daughters of Gaea, mother earth. They gave birth to many children who became the spirits of rivers and forests. All of nature was animated by them.

Prometheus was one of the wisest of the Titans whose name means 'foresighted'. He had forknowledge of the end of the his age and could see the Titans would be overthrown by the lesser race of the gods.

The war between the titans and the gods raged for 10 years horrible years but in the end the gods overwhelmed the titans. Prometheus had taken no part in the war and thus did not share the fate of the rest of his race.

Prometheus want among the new gods and gave these harsh new rulers gifts of wisdom and knowledge. He turned more and more to the art of shaping metels and the substances that came from the earth. He chose the lame son of Zeus, Hephaestos, the least haughty of the gods, and provided a forge and shared his knowledge of the earth. He taught him how to forge metals.

He pursued other crafts as well for he was skilled as a magicain so that in time the secret of life itself came to him. Prometheus was the deity who shaped men from clay and breathed into them the breath of life. Furthermore, it was Prometheus who brought to men the gift of fire.

With this gift of fire came the light of wisdom and the heat of unquenchable desire, and all the tings that make men greater than beasts and cause them to strive to acheive immortal fame.

The Olympian gods were angry, for they wished no rivals and claimed Prometheus had given mortals what the gods alone should possess. Yet the act could not be undone and the fire could not be quenched.

Zeus ordered Hephaestos to forge a chain of ADAMANTINE, the iron of the gods, that would be unbreakable and for Prometheus to be taken to the White mountains and be chained to the one called the Caucasus forever.

Zeus sent an eagle and a vulture to constantly torment him, tearing out his liver each day, and regrowing at night only to go thru it again. He was in eternal pain.

He was consoled by many nymphs, and spirits, and even men who tried to comfort him, but none could break his bonds. As ages past the relationship between gods and men improved until there was actually offspring of gods and women. One of these was Hercules, the son of Zeus.

Zeus had come to regret his punishment of Prometheus but was restrained by his own unbreakable oath. But when Hercules went to that wilderness of the White mountains, Zeus didn't drive him away, but allowed Hercules to free him.

When Prometheus was free, Zeus spoke to him that he must keep his oath of binding but would also allow Prometheus to be free. Zeus took a broken link of the chain of Adamantine and from Mt. Caucasus took a fragment of rock.

Zeus welded the stone to the link. He then took the hand of Prometheus and about his finger he closed the link of Adamantine and by this device kept his oath to chain the Titan to the rock of the Caucasus forever, and yet fulfilled his promise to let Prometheus walk free. This was how the first ring was made.

Men came to wear rings to honor Prometheus, the father of man and bringer of fire. The ring is a sign of the smith who is master of fire, and the magician who is master of life. Kings who wear rings as a sign of their descent from Prometheus and the titans who once ruled the earth.

SAURON: In Prometheus, the good Titan, we have a mirror opposite of Sauron, the evil sorcerer who brought death and darkness. However, when Sauron appeared to the elves in the second age in disguise as the mysterious stranger Annatar, he must have seemed everything to the Elves that Prometheus was to humans.

Only after Annatar tricked the Elves into forging the Rings of Power did they learn the terrible price of Annatar's gifts.

The price demanded of Prometheus's gifts was that the Titan himself be eternally bound and enslaved. The price demanded of Sauron's gifts was that the Elves be eternally bound and enslaved.

Curiously, Prometheus, the father of men, giver of fire and master of smiths, has a ring forged of iron in the Caucasian mountains: the very place where the secret of Iron-smelting was discovered.

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THESEUS:

There is an exact parallel in *The Lord of the Rings* to the climax of the Greek myth of Theseus and the minotaur. In the Greek tale, Theseus set out with a black sailed tribute ship for Crete and promised his father if he was victorious against the Minotaur he would change the sails to white as a signal of victory. He forgets to do so in his flush of triumph and his father commits suicide by jumping off a cliff.

In the Ring Trilogy, Denethor, the ruling steward of Gondor sees the black sailed ships of the enemy Corsair fleet sailing toward them, not realizing that Aragorn has captured them. He goes mad with grief and despair and commits suicide. But, like Theseus's father, Denethor is tragically mistaken.

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THE JUDEO-CHRISTIAN TRADITION:

The contribution of the Judeo-Christian tradition to Tolkien's imaginative writing is both paradoxical and profound. The early Judeo-Christian world is very unlike Tolkien's world for Tolkien purposely created a world that was without formal religion.

Tho Tolkien's characters did not quite worship the Valarian gods, their beliefs were much closer to the panentheism of the pagan Teutons, Celts and Greeks than to the henotheism or, later, monotheism of the Old testament Hebrews.

We have already discussed many parallels to the fall in covering the Silmarillion but I want to pick up the links to the ring. The strongest links between biblical legends and Tolkien's tales relate to beliefs in the power of rings.

by Biblical times, all kingdoms and nations had long accepted the tradition of the ring as a symbol of a monarch's authority. The king's ring not only marked him as monarch but could be said to possess power in itself.

Often in the king's absence, the ring or the ring's seal could be used to carry the full authority of the ruler. In Genesis, Joseph is given the Pharaoh's own ring to rule over all Egypt.

When Joseph interpreted the Pharaoh's dream after no one else could, the Pharaoh made him his chief counsellor. "and the Pharaoh took off his ring from his hand, and put it upon Joseph's hand, and arrayed him in vestures of fine linen and put a gold chain about his neck. Then the Pharaoh said to Joseph: "without thee no man shall lift up his hand or foot in all the land of Egypt."

Moses, who led the exodus of the Hebrews out of Egypt to the promised land of Israel, was commonly associated with the use of magic rings.

Tolkien draws a biblical parallel in *The Silmarillion* between his Elves and the Hebrew Tribes. Like these tribes, The Elves are a 'chosen people' who endure terrible hardships of mass migration to a 'promised land.

The 'Great Journey' of the Elves across the wilderness of Middle earth is to Eldamar, the promised homeland of the Elves in the Undying Lands; just as the Hebrews come to their promised homeland. Both are comparable in that they are divinely summoned: the Elves by the god Manwe, the Hebrews by the god YHWH.

If Tolkien uses certain biblical themes that connect his Elves with the Hebrews, it is also evident that his mortal Numenorians resemble the biblical Egyptians.

Tolkien states this directly in a letter of the late 1950's.

"The Numenorians of Gondor were proud, peculiar and archaic and I think are best pictured in Egyptian terms. In many ways they resembled "Egyptians"--the love of, and power to construct, the gigantic and massive. And their great interest in ancestry and in tombs... ."

The Reed sea event is paralleled in Tolkien when the King of Numenor whose navy follows the sea roads of the Elves to the Undying lands. Because he won't recognize the authority of the Valarian god, the King of Numenor and his mighty navy are swallowed up by the waters of the western sea.

SOLOMON'S MAGIC RING:

The most famous ring legend was linked with King Solomon. Tradition tells us that Solomon was, among other things, considered to be the most powerful magician of his age. These powers were attributed to his possession of a magic ring. This "Legend of King Solomon's ring" is certainly the tale that had very profound influence on Tolkien, on his imagination in composition of the ring trilogy.

There can be little doubt that Tolkien was familiar with this ancient biblical tale of a sorcerer-king who (like Sauron) used a magic ring to command all the demons of the earth, and bent them to the purpose of ruling his empire. Just as Solomon uses his magic ring to build his great temple on Moriah, So Sauron uses the One Ring to build his great tower in Mordor. Of all the rings of legend and myth, Solomon's ring most resembles the One Ring of *The Lord of the Rings*.

Solomon's Ring is also like Sauron's One Ring in that its power can corrupt its master; even one as wise as Solomon. In the figure of the demon Asmodeus we see the subtle agent of evil who corrupts the wise but fatally proud King Solomon of Israel, and thru possession of the ring causes his downfall.

In the figure of the demon Sauron we see the subtle agent of evil who corrupts the wise but fatally proud King Ar-Pharazon of Numenor, and through possession of the ring causes his downfall.

There are other parallels with biblical myth in Tolkien. Just as the Elven King Thingol succeeds in acquiring the brilliant, light radiating jewel called the Silmaril, so the Hebrew King Solomon succeeds in acquiring the brilliant, light-radiating jewel called the Schamir.

Both are heirlooms of their races: The Silmaril was once the sacred jewel of the ancestral leader of the Elves, Fëanor; while the Schamir was the sacred jewel of the ancestral leader of the Jews, Moses.

Once Solomon obtains the Schamir, it appears to fit perfectly on his ring and doubles the power of his ring and illuminates the 'One name' of God.

The story of Solomon's ring is tied up with the construction of the Temple. Progress on the Temple was very slow as YHWH had forbidden the use of Iron. A great multitude worked on it but they grew emaciated. One master builder came to Solomon and told him that at night, a vampire came and sucked his and his

workmen's blood and the same demon spirited away food and gold and other materials used in building the temple.

Solomon prayed to YHWH and Michael the archangel gave him a ring with which he could lock up all the demons of the earth and with their help build the temple. When he put on the ring, he understood the language of everything, the secrets of the earth, etc.

He harnessed the work of the demons, including Beelzebul, their leader. He imprisoned those who carried sickness and the others were put to work cutting stone and other things. Those who didn't cooperate were shut under the great seal into jars.

After Solomon obtained the Schamir, which only the demon Asmodeus knew where to find and was forced to reveal, he was warned by God in a dream about its doubling in power. Asmodeus was kept under bonds by Solomon in his palace as he was not cooperative.

One day Asmodeus enraptured the king with a tale of the power and visions of demons. Solomon asked how they could be so happy and gifted if a mere mortal like himself could keep their greatest prince under bonds. Asmodeus answered that Solomon had only to loosen his fetter and lend him the ring and he would prove his power and esstatic vision.

Solomon agreed and Asmodeus took the ring and placed it on his hand. by its doubled power the demon rose like a mountain before Solomon until one wing touched heaven and the other earth. He snatched up Solomon and hurled him out of Israel into the vast wilderness of the south.

The most authoritative version of this story reveals that Asmodeus conjured up a counterfeit Solomon who appeared in every way like the king (tho some of his wives and concubines were puzzled by their lord's strange new appetites).

Asmodeus himself flew away in freedom and hurled the ring into the Red sea. Solomon wandered for three years, an unrecognized beggar. He ended up as chief cook for an Ammonite king. Solomon fell in love with Naamah, the king's daughter and they were both taken to the desert to starve.

Solomon still knew the language of the wild things and they were able to survive until they came to the sea. Solomon helped a fisherman draw in his nets and was rewarded with a fish. When Naamah cleaned the fish she found a ring in its belly. Solomon put on the ring, gave thanks to YHWH, and transported himself and Naamah back to Jerusalem in a tree. The counterfeit Solomon vanished under the ring's seal.

Solomon was restored to his kingdom and great wealth but grew corrupted again. He even built a temple to Ashtaroath on Mount Moriah for his jebusite queen.

Then Asmodius brought word that the kingdom would be split at Solomon's death; that the temple and his books would be destroyed and the demons of disease would be released again.

Solomon repented, but the prophecies came true anyhow. Solomon died upright, leaning on his staff, and the demons continued to work on his plans for many years after, not knowing he was dead and the power of the ring was unmanned. At length a snake curled about the staff and it snapped and then the demons scattered.

The ring is thought to have been placed in the Holy of Holies in the Ark of the Covenant itself and never captured. A later magician went to rescue it when the soldiers of titus were destroying the temple in 70 AD. He saw it and touched it, but then fainted and was carried to a strange land where a voice told him that the ring had been taken back to heaven.
